

Measuring what you can't see day to day

Week 2 Lecture 1 · Looksmaxxing

Evidence-based appearance improvement · Autumn 2026

What we'll cover today

- **Why your eye lies to you** about daily change
- **Photo protocol:** front, side, and three-quarter angles
- **Lighting and distance:** the two variables that break comparisons
- **Tape measurement:** six points and when to re-measure
- **Bodyweight trend lines** versus single-day noise

Why you cannot track daily change by
looking in the mirror

The adaptation problem

Your brain updates its reference model of your face every time you look.

- You saw yourself hundreds of times this week
- Each viewing recalibrates your baseline
- After two weeks, you genuinely cannot remember what you looked like

This is not a character flaw. It is how perceptual adaptation works.

The fix: an objective record created before adaptation occurs.

What a photo baseline actually gives you

The camera does not adapt. It records one moment with fixed parameters.

Three things a photo series gives you that a mirror cannot:

1. **Comparison across time:** week two versus week ten is a literal overlay
2. **Angle objectivity:** side-profile changes (posture, fat distribution) are invisible to yourself without a mirror and a very specific angle
3. **Accountability:** you cannot unconsciously revise a JPEG

Week-zero photos are worth more in week ten than they are today.

Photo protocol

The three reference angles

Each angle captures different information:

Angle	What it shows
Front	Facial symmetry, skin tone, shoulder width
Side	Posture, jaw-to-neck line, gut protrusion
Three-quarter	Facial structure, cheekbone definition, overall impression

Take all three every week, in the same order, in the same session.

Setup variables that matter

Five variables produce valid comparisons. Change any one and the comparison breaks.

1. **Camera height:** mid-chest level, measured from floor
2. **Distance:** same step-count or cm from wall each week
3. **Light source:** one consistent source, same position, same time of day
4. **Background:** plain wall, no objects that shift over weeks
5. **Timing:** same day and time of week, same grooming state (before styling)

Write all five down in a note you will find next week.

Light is the variable most people get wrong

- Same window, same time of day
- Or same ring light, same position
- Shadows fall in the same places each week
- Window light on Monday, overhead light on Friday
- Morning light versus evening light from same window
- Flash versus no flash

Consistent light (valid comparison)

Inconsistent light (invalid comparison)

Inconsistent light changes apparent skin tone, shadow depth, and apparent face shape. It looks like change when nothing changed.

Body measurements

Why tape measurements matter more than the scale

Bodyweight tracks total mass, not composition. A man who gains two kilograms of muscle and loses two kilograms of fat weighs exactly the same but looks meaningfully different.

Tape measurements at consistent points track what composition change actually looks like:

- Waist circumference going down with stable weight means fat loss at the midsection
- Arm circumference going up with stable weight suggests muscle gain
- These are the signals that matter for appearance goals

The six measurement points

Record in this order so you never miss one:

1. **Neck** - mid-neck, just below the larynx
2. **Chest** - widest point, tape horizontal, arms at sides
3. **Waist** - narrowest torso point, exhale normally first
4. **Hips** - widest point of hips and glutes
5. **Upper arm** - dominant arm, mid-bicep, relaxed (not flexed)
6. **Thigh** - mid-thigh, dominant leg, standing relaxed

Re-measure every four weeks, same conditions, same time of day.

Bodyweight: the trend line beats any single reading

A single morning weight is contaminated by:

- How much you ate and drank yesterday
- Sodium intake and water retention
- Glycogen stores from exercise
- Bowel contents

None of these reflect body composition. A single reading can swing 1-3 kg in either direction with no fat or muscle change.

The fix: weigh daily, take the seven-day rolling average. That average moves with composition change, not noise.

Reading a trend line

Week	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Avg
1	82.4	83.1	82.8	82.6	83.0	82.5	82.2	82.7
2	82.1	82.3	81.9	82.4	82.0	81.8	82.1	82.1
3	81.8	81.6	82.0	81.5	81.7	81.4	81.6	81.7

The trend line here is clear: -1.0 kg over three weeks.

Day-to-day: confusing noise.

Week-to-week average: clean signal.

Take-aways

1. Your brain adapts to your appearance daily. A camera does not. That is why photos are a measurement tool, not vanity.
2. Five setup variables produce valid photo comparisons. Changing any one makes the comparison misleading.
3. Tape measurements track composition changes the scale misses entirely.
4. Single-day bodyweight contains one to three kg of noise. Seven-day averages are the signal.
5. Week-zero data has no emotional charge. Measure honestly now. The comparison in week ten requires it.

"Without a standardized baseline, you are comparing your memory to reality. Memory always edits in your favor or against it, rarely accurately."

- Lecture notes, Week 2 · Looksmaxxing, Autumn 2026

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Set up your photo station, take week-zero photos, build your habit-stack on paper
- **Reading:** Week 2 reading, baseline, sleep, and the habit machine
- **Lecture 2:** Sleep, circadian rhythm, and recovery , what restricted sleep does to your face, hormones, and ability to build habit
- **No assignment due this week**